

# Consciousness and the Logic of Authentic Development in Bernard Lonergan

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## Abstract

*The search for solutions to national problems in Nigeria draws one's attention to the reflections of Bernard Lonergan. In his methodology of understanding, he believes that consciousness is the basis of insight and that quality of insight shapes the human personality, society and history. He argues that the development of human consciousness, as it transcends and matures from simple awareness to optimal comprehension, follows "transcendental precepts." These precepts are the fulcra for the formation of consciousness and conscience, and are guided by the "law of emergent probability", which holds that one cannot correctly move from one state of consciousness to a higher level without satisfying the previous demands of the earlier state of consciousness. This article will explore these intellectual insights of Lonergan, and offer them as options for the formation of citizens who can engage positively in re-building Nigeria.*

## Introduction

The Nigerian society of today is rippled with myriad of problems. There is widespread culture of inattentiveness and lack of deeper comprehension of basic issues necessary for the construction of a functioning society. Personal and social values are at haywire and the sense of pragmatic control of the structures of art and science of development are lacking too. This is why we lack productive personnel and progressive politics, where citizens are equipped to run and make their lives worth living. This syndrome of poor routine existentiality is in want of insight, creativity and authenticity. This is why barrage of theories for a better society has been proffered by well meaning scholars and elites. In this light, therefore, this work intends to engage some of the existential issues facing Nigeria with a philosophical option, which is an effort for a better Nigeria. It will do this, using inspirations from the philosophical reflections of Bernard Lonergan.

Lonergan, in his methodology of understanding, delved into the study of the structures of human consciousness, and proposed some prerequisite principles for the development and use of the instruments of consciousness, which he termed "transcendental precepts". This concept of "transcendental precepts" was born in the context of his search for a universal method which, he hopes, could be used to study anything knowable by the human mind. Initially, he called this method "Generalized Empirical Method" (GEM), and as issues evolved, he renamed it "the Transcendental method" (TM). However, he, sometimes, used the terms GEM and TM interchangeably depending on the matter under study.<sup>1</sup> Either as GEM or TM, he defined method as "a normative pattern of recurrent and related operations yielding cumulative and progressive results."<sup>2</sup> This means that method involves distinct operations, where each operation is related to the others, and the set of relations of this process forms a pattern guided by intelligence.<sup>3</sup> Thus, method is the correct way of awareness, making inquiry, searching and handling issues in knowledge, resolving the techniques of existential dynamics and making responsible decisions on norms or values. That is to say that

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<sup>1</sup> Lonergan used "Generalized Empirical Method (GEM)" and "Transcendental Method" (TM), to describe his idea of method. Cf. C. King "Introduction to Transcendental/General Empirical Method" in *Society For the Study of Insight, The Alsofar Group*, January 15, 2007.

<sup>2</sup> Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1972), 4.

<sup>3</sup> Cf. Humphrey Uchenna Ani, *Critical History According to Bernard Lonergan* (Rome: Gregorian and Biblical Press, 2017), 76.

intelligent human knowledge and responsible human actions are the results of method.<sup>4</sup> Discussing the application of this method led Lonergan to the anatomy of the structures and principles or precepts that guide the growth of knowledge and meaning, otherwise called the “Transcendental Precepts”.

### **Anatomy of Consciousness and the Transcendental Precepts**

In his anatomy of consciousness through his methodological studies, Lonergan argues that method follows four structural principles in the ascending maturation of the human consciousness and the formation of enlightened human conscience. He called them the “transcendental precepts”, which constitute the methodic steps of understanding and generation of meaning. These precepts are the levels of engagement of human reason in the process of understanding and making of meaning. They are structured into four levels, which include the empirical, intelligent, rational and responsible levels.

#### **The Empirical level**

At this level, there is a patterning of consciousness to pay attention to the empirical experiences around oneself. Consciousness is educated to recognize the physical and social basics like the immediate data, objects and events around oneself. This attentiveness to the immediate environment implies drawing the mind to the awareness of the physical realities, needs, desires and values, which relate to one as an individual. This can be exercised in seven patterns of experiences: biological, aesthetic, dramatic, practical, social, intellectual and mystical.<sup>5</sup> Forming and raising one’s consciousness to immediate experiences and needs can help one engage in the cultivation of one’s physical empowerment, achieving satisfaction, building basic human skills, physical or personal good and learning. Here, one will be able to provide one’s basic needs and engage in the realization of personal contentment, self-worth and personal peace. At this level, one’s mind develops what John Dewey calls “active intelligence,”<sup>6</sup> and one will be able to apply one’s mental faculties to procure physical or personal good for rudimentary survival and confident personality.<sup>7</sup>

At this level too, consciousness is formed to have common sense knowledge, which “is concerned with the relations of things to us.”<sup>8</sup> It is a sense essential for physicality and practicalities of life.<sup>9</sup> One’s consciousness is, here, enabled to help one handle things that keep one alive, sustain one’s health, form basic social relationships, seminal skills for general existentiality, basic aesthetics,

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<sup>4</sup> Cf. Michael Shute, *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History* (Lanham: University Press of America, Inc, 1951), 14.

<sup>5</sup> Cf. Bernard Lonergan, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1992), 205-231.

<sup>6</sup> Samuel E. Stumpf & James Fieser, *Philosophy: History and Problems* (New York: Lisa More, 2008), 381.

<sup>7</sup> Lonergan posited four forms of the “good” that correspond to the four transcendental precepts: empirical, intellectual, rational and responsible. There is the “personal good” or “particular good” like food, shelter, health, clothing, personal property, etc which are products of an intelligent conscious experience or attentive life. The second is the “intellectual good”, which is a product of consciousness with insight or understanding like intelligently organized social order (the good of the order: family, education, economy, politics, etc). The third is the “cultural good” which is a product of critical and civil consciousness like sense of aesthetics, patriotism, respect, integrity, sincerity, dignity, humanity, etc. The fourth is the “transcendental good” which refers to higher values as morality and piety or spirituality. It is the fruit of highly refined consciousness through self-appropriation, self-authenticity and deep sense of mystery in ones’ personality and existentiality. It is a good integrated to the Divine which satisfies the innermost arc of the human person, often identified with man’s religious or sacred nature. Cf. Joseph Ogbonnaya, *Lonergan, Social Transformation, and Sustainable Human Development* (Oregon: Wipf and Stock Publishers, 2013), 94.

<sup>8</sup> Lonergan, *Insight*, 204.

<sup>9</sup> Cf. Humphrey Uchenna Ani, *Topics in Epistemology* (Enugu: Snaap Press, 2019), 3.

decency, behavior, and so on. It heightens one's mind to the physical presence of things, others, basic beauty and values of life which Lonergan represented as physical or "particular good."<sup>10</sup> Consciousness is formed to meet up with primary demands of human life as it prepares to aspire or transcend to more intelligent challenges of life, when it engages in higher order comprehension.

### **The Intellectual level**

At the intellectual level, the normative pattern of operations is involved in intelligent comprehensions or organization of things around oneself. Consciousness enters into deeper understanding and pursuance of answers to questions of Why? or What for? of the things around oneself. This implies making deeper inquiries, generating insights and formulations of systems or theories that help in organizing oneself and one's society. Here, accumulated insights are expressed in intelligent application of what is known, grasp of situations and mastery of theoretical and practical domains.<sup>11</sup> This intelligent personal or social engagement with the existential order creates what Lonergan calls "the 'good of the order', which refers to the intelligent pattern of relationships that makes it possible for everyone to attain his aspirations and need by each contributing to the need of the other and finding one's protection through giving assistance in what protects everyone."<sup>12</sup> It is the basis of constructive human inter-subjectivity, which "ensures the recurrence of schemes of events or structures for the provision of the good not only for oneself but for other people who are members of the civil community."<sup>13</sup> The good of the order, "consists in an intelligible pattern of relationships that conditions the fulfillment of each man's desire by his contributions to the fulfillment of the desires of others, and similarly protects each from the object of his fears in the measure he contributes to warding off the objects feared by others."<sup>14</sup>

Good of the order means the intellectual "products of practical intelligence as the polity, the economic, technology, social arrangements like marriage and family as an institution."<sup>15</sup> Ability of people's consciousness to have intelligently formed system, corporation and specialization that makes it possible for them to contribute to the society and receive benefits from the society in a mutual complementary manner is what constitutes the "good of the order."<sup>16</sup> It ensures, protects and preserves the common good in a society. And common good refers to the good of all in the society-material, moral, cultural or institutional, which members of the society provide for themselves to satisfy their relational obligation for their collective interest. "Its value is the most comprehensive in comparison with the individual values."<sup>17</sup> "Good of the order" helps people realize the priority of common good above personal good. It helps a society craft intelligent laws; create functional technology, strong and sustainable economy, progressive polity and stable and secure domestic structures. It spurs and sustains social consciousness and responsibility.

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<sup>10</sup> Ogbonnaya, *Lonergan, Social Transformation, and Sustainable Human Development*, 94.

<sup>11</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 10.

<sup>12</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Insight*, 238.

<sup>13</sup> Ogbonnaya, *Lonergan, Social Transformation, and Sustainable Human Development*, 94.

<sup>14</sup> Lonergan, *Insight* 238.

<sup>15</sup> Ogbonnaya, *Lonergan, Social Transformation, and Sustainable Human Development*, 94.

<sup>16</sup> Brian Cronin, *Value Ethics: A Lonergan Perspective* (Nairobi: Consolata Institute of Philosophy Press, 2006), 146.

<sup>17</sup> Johannes Messner, *Social Ethics* (London: Herder Book Co., 1965), 571.

### **The Rational level**

The rational level entails critical development of consciousness, where it logically strives to be critical in its evaluation of issues. And a widely rational or critical society is better suited to examine naïve beliefs, stereotypes, un-enlightened traditions, crude customs and static social structures. A critical citizenry can lead to widespread culture of objectivity among citizens, deep sense of judgment and unbiased examination of personal and social issues. In the rational engagement of consciousness, “there is the potential for the general analysis of interiority grounded in self-appropriation which could count for the whole realm of proportionate being.”<sup>18</sup> People at this level are supposed to evolve a more authentic personality that is guided by informed moral dispositions. The goal would be to create the “good as the possible object of rational choice,”<sup>19</sup> whereby the human subject makes rational and responsible choices, modifying the society as virtuous persons capable of building a solid and healthy civilization with others.<sup>20</sup> Rational consciousness in a society brings transformation of cultural dynamics, generates yardstick for measuring meaning, judging and evaluating the physical and social goods that bind a society. The rational level of consciousness is the creative level where the higher powers of reason and judgment can provide the superstructures or core principles that govern and mediate the infrastructural achievements of the practical and technological faculties in a society. It is at this level that consciousness is supposed to help people generate inspiring “cultural good” like objectivity, sincerity, integrity, civility, dignity, honesty, patriotism, inner positive pride, and higher intelligibility for responsibility in their society. It is also at this disposition that the mind is prepared for making responsible decisions for the best interest of all at the fourth precept of consciousness, which is the responsible level.

### **The Responsible level**

After developing a critical mind, one is consciously habituated to face definite decisions of life: “to do or not to do”. There are some questions that arise at this level: what is it to be done with what one has known and judged right? Will one’s decision over the insight be beneficial or not, and could it be right when made? How will one’s decision promote the common good? It is a moral cross-road, where one may decide to follow the provisions of insight or decide against it. It is the optimal level in the transcendence of consciousness, which equally begins the ethical formation of one’s conscience. Here, epistemology transcends into ethics, and cultivated insight transcends to moral position of conscience, as one allows what one knows to decide what one does and what one ought to do.

If at this level, one consciously makes a decision based on the truth of insight and judgment, one’s action will most likely be right and good, and one will be considered authentic. But if one decides consciously on the contrary, one’s action could be wrong and bad, and it will be considered inauthentic. This is why acting from well-informed consciousness and conscientiousness is what makes one and one’s action authentic. Authenticity, for Lonergan, means having an informed consciousness and conscience, and acting consciously and conscientiously from an enlightened self through the transcendental precepts. Authenticity therefore means being attentive to the experiences around oneself; exercising intelligent understanding over one’s experiences; critically drawing reasonable judgments over what one understands and making responsible decision based on one’s

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<sup>18</sup> Shute, *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History*, 44-45.

<sup>19</sup> Lonergan, *Insight*, 624.

<sup>20</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 34.

reasonable judgment and conscience. It is the achievement of self-transcendent consciousness through the transcendental precepts: being attentive, being intelligent, being reasonable and being responsible.<sup>21</sup> It entails habit of cultivating the right insight and just sense of awareness, understanding, reasonableness and responsibility. It is the fruit of “polished” personality, in which one becomes “enwisdomised” or enlightened in activity, intellectuality, morality and religiosity.

The transcendental precepts in the methodology of Lonergan also help one to understand the drivers of developments in a person and a society. Lonergan argues that persons and societies guided by these precepts will achieve insight in their development. If the precepts are ignored, one or society will be driven by “oversight” and constant mistakes, which can spell doom on the individuals or the state in the long run. Thus, one can say that the achievement of the transcendental precepts, according to Lonergan, is the making of authentic persons and societies driven by insight, and consequently, the generation of progress in the individuals and the society. This is because when one acts intelligently, one would be able to do things correctly, and would be able to seek solutions in making his society better. If a wide range of people in a society are driven by insight, such a society would be civil. It would adhere to good counsel, make responsible decisions and engage in progressive projects. When challenged by problems, it will be better prepared and empowered to make right decisions that can yield positive results. This is why William Matthews commented that Lonergan’s “transcendental precepts” for the formation of individuals and society breed insight which is a “natural dialectic” as well as an idealized account of human action as being consistently intelligent and responsible.<sup>22</sup> Where there is insight, there will be “a series of ascending general principles each followed by expansion, antithesis and a soluble problem.”<sup>23</sup> About a society guided by insight, Michael Shute states:

They always did what was attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible. As a result of the observance of the transcendental precepts problems would be noticed, previously unrealized possibilities would be grasped, unworkable proposals would be rejected while workable ones would be embraced, and decisions would be based on an unbiased evaluation of the situation. The implication is an ever-increasing progress or ideal line.<sup>24</sup>

A society driven by insight can meet up with the demands of practical intelligence facing her, and be able to work out ways of resolving them. It will be able to develop, expand and apply intelligently, the arts, science and technology necessary for the technicalities that make for progress. Insight situates a society on a stage in which “there is the development of scientific theory, which proposes theories to account for material and cultural phenomena and which directs the application of theory to practice. This progressive cycle can advance a society to the level of theoretical control as developments of theory direct practice.”<sup>25</sup>

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<sup>21</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 9.

<sup>22</sup> Cf. George Whelan, *Redeeming History-Social Concern in Bernard Lonergan and Robert Doran* (Rome: Gregorian and Biblical Press, 2013), 34.

<sup>23</sup> William Matthews, *Lonergan’s Quest: A Study of Desire in the Authoring of Insight* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2005), 25.

<sup>24</sup> Shute, *The Origins of Lonergan’s Notion of the Dialectic of History*, 43.

<sup>25</sup> Shute, *The Origins of Lonergan’s Notion of the Dialectic of History*, 44.

However, Lonergan posits that the “transcendental precepts,” in the maturation of consciousness from one level to another, is not automatic in its process. The condition for one’s consciousness to transcend from one level of the precepts to another depends on a logic of satisfaction of a previous order of consciousness. This is why an inattentive mind may not be disposed to transcend to understanding, and why an ignorant mind cannot reason or judge better, and why an unreasonable or unjust mind cannot honestly make a just and responsible decision. He calls this rule guiding the working and evolution of consciousness and conscience, the “law of emergent probability.”<sup>26</sup>

### **Law of Emergent Probability and the Logic of Authenticity**

The law of emergent probability, according to Lonergan, is the law that guides method either as GEM or TM as indicated above. By implication, it guides the “transcendental precepts” which are parts of “method” in the formation and development of human consciousness. This law, Lonergan asserts, claims that there are schemes of recurrent activities which yield new results when the conditions of the earlier schemes are fulfilled and functioning well.<sup>27</sup> It presumes that objects of intentionality have internal logic.<sup>28</sup> The law upholds that the condition for the probable emergence of new effects depends on the conditions of earlier operations. It argues that “combinations of events possess a probability, and that probability jumps, first when a scheme becomes concretely possible in virtue of the fulfillment of its prior conditions, and secondly when the scheme begins actually to function.”<sup>29</sup> This law, however, does not claim that one scheme directly causes another. That would be deterministic. It rather says that the probable emergence of a subsequent scheme depends on the existence of the preceding one.<sup>30</sup> “The actual functioning of earlier schemes in the series fulfils the conditions of the probability of the functioning of later schemes.”<sup>31</sup>

This law implies that in the operations of consciousness and its transcendence, an internal logic demands that attentiveness to experience must be satisfied as condition for the probability of understanding. Proper understanding will also fulfill the condition for critical judgment to be made, and this in turn fulfills the condition for the emergence of right and responsible decision. In relation to the good that each level of consciousness produces, it means that failure to satisfy personal good would hamper genuine inter-subjectivity and social order; to lack social consciousness and obligations would render cultural good like honesty and integrity empty; and absence of such higher values as integrity would make transcendental good like spirituality hollow. Spirituality without integrity can only lead to hypocrisy of religion.

### **Finding the Right Logic in the Nigerian Task**

Sequel to above, Lonergan maintains that quality of a state depends on the quality of citizens, and the quality of citizens depend on the quality of their states of consciousness which is guided by an internal logic, where logic means “the totality of all laws guiding the human thought.”<sup>32</sup> This is to say that the minds and hearts of people must follow certain principles of progress as enshrined in the transcendental precepts to develop as individuals who will later develop their nation. Thus, only a

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<sup>26</sup> Lonergan, *Insight*, 145.

<sup>27</sup> Cf. Ani, *Critical History*, 94.

<sup>28</sup> Logic here is used as the principles guiding the operation of a mechanism and the entire structure of laws guiding human thinking. Cf. Francis Offor, *Essentials of Logic* (Ibadan: Book Wright Publishers, 2010), 3.

<sup>29</sup> Lonergan, *Insight*, 144-150.

<sup>30</sup> Cf. Whelan, *Redeeming History*, 77.

<sup>31</sup> Lonergan, *Insight*, 145.

<sup>32</sup> Offor, *Essentials of Logic*, 3.

correct state of consciousness can lay the first foundation necessary for personal and national development. Forming and producing an intelligent citizenry and government who can intelligently organize a society into industrious, civil, critical, creative and transformative community should be the keystone in building a developed nation. Citizens are more likely to freely imbibe civic discipline, respect just laws and embrace patriotic calls when they are enlightened and equipped to create and appreciate these values. Democratic principles logically can only function and flourish where there is enlightened civil culture. Democracy could only be good when those who exercise it are informed and not driven by blind passions. When citizens are properly guided by a clear national philosophy, they can build on that to embrace other principles such as fairness, equity and impartiality in their personal and public lives.

In Nigeria today, there are indices that show that lack of attentiveness to rudimentary essentials for building personal and social values is central to myriad of problems facing the nation. This connects to widespread ignorance over primary pragmatic theories and lack of control of technical operations in both arts and sciences in the efforts at building the nation. Such widespread poor or no know-how breeds non-resourceful personnel who have very limited sense of judgment, and as such incapable of rising to the high demands of building a strong state in Nigeria. They settle to routine existentiality bereft of creativity. Both leaders and the led are complicit in this low level existentiality. There is a loss of grip and control of the knowledge of the basics in our environment. How much do we know or apply ourselves to the rudiments of our environment? What do we really know about our potentialities and liabilities? What national philosophy or ideology guides us? What common vision do we share as a nation? Do we have the basic epistemic instruments to know ourselves-informed system of education, citizens with critical and clear judgment, available data and statistics on the nation? Individual Nigerians developing the mindset for these critical criteria and interrogatives are very important in tackling the Nigerian task.

To tackle the Nigerian task, we must start by finding the right logic for the formation of mindsets of individual Nigerians. We can do this, using sociological instruments like the family, schools, universities, churches and political platforms. One cannot talk of national development in Nigeria, when a large population of the people do not understand how an organized society should work, do not have proper judgment of their peculiarities and practicalities and are unable to engage in consistent responsible decisions in their private and public lives. We may have good laws but they are hardly practiced because the agencies that should either enforce or practice them are very poorly formed and disposed for that. If Nigeria has to progress, it must follow a method of development that must start from the basics and progress to higher order existentiality. It must start from a kind of logic in which the individual is the centre of social formation, and from the individual, there will be a centrifugal energy for the development of the entire national character in every axes of the country.

The emergence of a developed Nigeria is only possible in the development of individual Nigerians, not just in making bogus state and national policies. A serious effort in our national task as Nigerians must start from the individual character to the larger house of state craft. This is to say that national character today in Nigeria must begin with the individual character of every Nigerian. It is the individual Nigerian that is the first agent in the process of development of the vital virtues of the entire nation. The application of the Lonerganian “transcendental precepts” in this regard will be a good option in the generation of national consciousness and soul for a functioning system in Nigeria. We must develop a type of education, at formal and informal levels, in which people are formed to

be attentive to relevant issues that affect them and the nation, where people are formed to develop deep insights over such relevant issues, have critical and just judgments over them, and be able to make right decisions based on them. We must develop a system of formation that enables citizens to provide their personal good, be socially conscious and dutiful, civil in character and responsible in private and public engagements.

Our education must help people pay serious attention to immediate issues around them, identify their potentialities and to develop insights which can help them master and utilize them with the right logic and theories. It must be able to craft a public system to change the typical Nigerian psyche of today, and to transform our modes of consciousness to be more critical in social, moral and even spiritual dimensions of our existentiality. Widespread uncritical mentality seen in viral gullibility and religious naivety constitute a major tool in the hands of political demagogues and religious charlatans in Nigeria, whose stock-in-trade is the swindling of public emotions and manipulation of minds to their selfish interest. Building an intelligent social and sustainable structure will help in curbing such social maladies. The possibility of the emergence of a civil society in Nigeria, in which people are trained to cultivate and live with a culture of higher values and authenticity in both moral and spiritual matters, can be mediated with Lonergan's transcendental precepts, which will be a good method in the formation of individual and national states of consciousness. However, the application of the transcendental precepts may not also be without some hitches and counter arguments as one may reason.

### **Evaluation of the Lonerganian Thesis on Consciousness and Progress**

In Lonergan's conceptual schemes, the logic of formation of consciousness through the transcendental precepts is based on the primary assumption that every awareness would be an awareness of positive experiences or perceptions. The understanding that follows in the next level would always be positive comprehension or positive insight, and so the rest of the series in the precepts. But how if a toxic environment, like a very corrupt society, constitutes the objects of one's perceptions or experiences? There is no gainsaying the fact that negative expositions and complicated experiences may rather generate negative knowledge rather than positives ones. If one pays attention to more negative or socially dysfunctional experiences, one is more likely to become an "evil genius" rather than develop genuine insight for creativity and authenticity.

Would negative empirical experiences and expositions be able to produce a positive consciousness and insight about something good? Is it not more likely to help one develop smart and crooked minds for evil and destructive aptitudes? Will teaching someone the dynamics of evil developments be able to generate an educated person in the right sense of the word or a criminal wizard? Would one's consciousness not rather be deformed from the onset, if one's objects of perception are prevalently the evil ones? If one's experiences are predominantly negative and toxic, it is likely that one's consciousness would emerge warped and crooked. In a situation where one is wrongly taught or where a society deliberately creates a persistent tradition of falsehood and "maleducation", one's consciousness may not be expected to achieve the higher comprehension and meaning at the end. What this means for the "transcendental precepts" of Lonergan is that if the first level is faulty, the subsequent levels/precepts: intellectual, rational and responsible, will either progress on negative streams or be trapped in evil tangle.

One may argue from the above that part of why the Nigerian society is not making much progress in the formation of the right citizens could be as a result of protracted and systemic toxic negative



experiences. Prolonged negativity rather than make the citizens authentic may make them complicated and geniuses in crime and evil. Consistent negative exposition may end up creating people who consciously reject insight and deliberately harden their consciences when and where they are expected to act with rational insight and moral responsibility. And if this should be the case, is it also possible for one to pull off from such evil quagmire, by any other means other than the intelligent method? In this light, Lonergan asked pertinent questions: “What happens insofar as people are inattentive, unintelligent, unreasonable, or irresponsible? What happens then is various forms of aberration or signs of decline.”<sup>33</sup> What happens when people are not asking the right questions and not paying proper attention to the issues that are pertinent to each level of the engagement of reason?

When the rights questions are ignored and there is a tradition of inattentiveness and evil, it raises an anti-thesis against insight and progress in individuals and the society. A person’s consciousness and the society become steeped in what Lonergan called “oversight”. William Matthews aptly describes it as the “dialectic of sin”. It is a situation in which one or a society consciously becomes un-attentive, un-intelligent, un-reasonable, un-critical and irresponsible. Here, there is a deliberate violation of intelligent functional order which could lead to abnormality in the dramatic subject and the entire society.<sup>34</sup> When a person or society opts for “oversight”, he consciously refuses insight and creates the platform for the emergence of structural aberrations and distortions, which Lonergan termed “bias.” Bias creates “a series of descending general principles, each followed by an evil expansion.”<sup>35</sup> When there is accumulation of un-thoughtful and wrongful decisions, mistakes and errors, as a result of “oversight”, there would be retrogression and decline. Thus, while insight generates authenticity, integrity and progress, oversight breeds in-authenticity, emptiness and retrogress in individuals and the nation. And these effects of oversight all lead lead to “bias”.

“Bias,” according to Lonergan, refers to the existential distortions in individuals and society. He categorized it into four forms: dramatic, individual, group, and general.<sup>36</sup> As Joseph Ogbonnaya notes, the first which is the “dramatic bias incapacitates people who are so affected at the subconscious level that they are unable to generate insights requisite for progress and development.”<sup>37</sup> When people or society have dramatic bias, their common sense and other elementary passions and potentialities are vitiated and deviated. They develop split motivations and neural obsessive complex.<sup>38</sup> Dramatic bias leads to “individual bias” in which individuals develop smart strategies to manipulate and exploit the intelligent social system like the “good of the order” to their personal advantage.<sup>39</sup> Widespread “individual bias” gives birth to “group bias” in which there is a deliberate exclusion of fruitful ideas and mutilation of some by compromise for the interest of a particular group.<sup>40</sup> When this is maintained, then a society collapses into “general bias” in which there is a calculated habit and tradition of rejection

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<sup>33</sup> Bernard Lonergan, *Early Works on Theological Method I* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2010), 507.

<sup>34</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Insight*, 212-214.

<sup>35</sup> Matthews, *Lonergan’s Quest*, 126.

<sup>36</sup> Cf. Ani, *Critical History*, 312.

<sup>37</sup> Joseph Ogbonnaya “Lonergan As Therapy For Confused Cultures-An African Response.” In *Lonergan’s Anthropology Revisited-The Next Fifty Years of Vatican II*, ed. George Whelan (Rome: Gregorian and Biblical Press, 2015), 258.

<sup>38</sup> Cf. Humphrey Uchenna Ani, “The Dialectics of Insight and Oversight in Social Reconstruction”, *Bigard Theological Studies*, July-Dec.2019, Vol. 39.No.2, 9.

<sup>39</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Early Works on Theological Method I*, 246..

<sup>40</sup> Cf. Ogbonnaya, *Lonergan, Social Transformation, and Sustainable Human Development*, 75.

of questions that lead to higher insights and higher values.<sup>41</sup> People habituate themselves with dysfunctional routine and refuse to progress in all intent and action. A situation of this kind, which is not far from what Nigeria is today will need some solutions to be saved. In such a situation, Lonergan would propose a third dialectic-moral and spiritual conjugate, which constitutes the synthesis of his reflections on this epistemological sociology.

### Conclusion

To restore a fallen society, Lonergan proposes some solutions based on his concepts of “sublation”, “psychic conversion” and “cosmopolis”. Sublation has to do with negating and isolating the negative options in a system in order to preserve its positive elements and to raise the positive elements to higher levels with greater comprehension and meaning.<sup>42</sup> In this process:

What sublates goes beyond what is sublated, introduces something new and distinct, puts everything on a new basis, yet so far from interfering with the sublated or destroying it, on the contrary needs it, includes it, preserves all its proper features and properties, and carries them forward to a fuller realization within a richer context.<sup>43</sup>

Lonergan proposed that healing a society can be achieved through a sublation of precepts and meaning in a way that incorporates and promotes previous understanding and values to finer planes. His idea of sublation is contrary to the Hegelian idea of sublation in which the dialectics of thoughts and values operate in what Lonergan considers “conceptualist, closed, necessitarian and immanent”,<sup>44</sup> and where new thesis cancels previous thesis as antithesis and does not preserve the cumulative understanding and meaning of the past. As he captured his position on sublation:

Our development is both the accumulation of insights moving to higher viewpoints and the reversal of the aberrations that were brought about by the interference of alien desire. Hegel’s absolute is a terminal concept that generates no anti-thesis to be sublated in a higher synthesis; we recognize a manifold of instances of the virtually unconditioned, and through them attain knowledge of proportionate being in its distinctions and relations.<sup>45</sup>

He maintains that sublation engages in concrete prospective totality to be known by answering correctly the totality of questions of intelligence and for reflection which is a basic step in curbing the distortions of oversight and decline. This admits the historical expansion of practical common sense, to the diversity of philosophic methods and systems.<sup>46</sup> In Lonerganian sublation, unlike in Hegel’s, where dialectics cancels out already gained knowledge, there is the permission for the accumulation of insights in which no knowledge is lost, and in which stages of the precepts: cognitional (experiential awareness), epistemological (intelligent understanding) and metaphysical (critical intelligibility) are sublated in the intentional (responsible interiority) stage of decision for higher viewpoints and values.<sup>47</sup> This process “promotes the subject from cognitional to moral self-

<sup>41</sup> Cf. John Dadosky, “Healing the Psychological Subject: Towards a Fourfold Notion of Conversion?”, *Theoforum*, 35:1, 2004, 76.

<sup>42</sup> Sublation is from the Latin word, *sublatus*, *sublatio* meaning to deny, detach, remove, elevate and to lift up.

<sup>43</sup> Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 241.

<sup>44</sup> Lonergan, *Insight*, 447.

<sup>45</sup> Lonergan, *Insight*, 447.

<sup>46</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Insight*, 447.

<sup>47</sup> Cf. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 316.

transcendence. It sets him on a new, existential level of consciousness and establishes him as an originating value.”<sup>48</sup> Through this, one or a society would gain the power of love to enable him or them to accept the suffering involved in undoing the effects of decline.<sup>49</sup> It can generate the moral personality capable of resisting the dramatic bias, and refusing the unjust benefits of individual or general bias. Thus, developing a society in which citizens consciously and honestly work to provide their personal good, intelligently live out their social consciousness, generate higher rational cultures and engage in interiority that is responsible and authentic. This is how the moral energy for the conversion of mind and heart is created. This is also how the stage is set for what Gerard Whelan commenting on Lonergan called the “supernatural dialectic.”<sup>50</sup>

The supernatural dialectic is the sum and synthesis of moral dialectics and dynamics of a society captured in a saving mystery. It is the redeeming supernatural intervention in human history, coupled with collective conversion of evil mind to good will as a people decide or opt for a better life. Conversion of consciousness and attitude is possible through an enshrinement of new redeeming virtues and spiritual conjugates as seen in Divine faith, hope and love. It brings a higher integration of the moral and the spiritual, and controls the elements that otherwise are non-systematic, irrational or affective, by transforming those elements unto good.<sup>51</sup> It demands what Robert Doran while interpreting Lonergan calls “psychic conversion.”<sup>52</sup> Psychic conversion can come through new teachings, education and enlightened religious practices like prayer, sacrifices, etc, which can inspire people to pick up new faith and hope for their recovery despite the endemic social mess they may find themselves. It can help people develop new sense of mystery enlightened by fresh insight and honest new questions for social reconstruction. It can spur an enlightened morality and piety which can help a people build new social standards and ideals which Lonergan termed “cosmopolis”. And by this, he meant:

The standard or ideal world (not in the Platonic sense) where the subject and society are led by the principles of wisdom and goodness; and in which every dimension of life is regulated by these principles. It checks the human inclination or dominance of the love of ego, the love of wealth, the love of power, the love of tribe, the love of class, the love of race, the love of ideology, the love of pleasures, and the love of honour.<sup>53</sup>

Imbibing the precepts of “cosmopolis” will refine the subjects in a society through enlightenment in such a way that they can be the best citizens of the world irrespective of the nationality or ethnic group they were born, which colour their skins bear, and personal interests they may have.<sup>54</sup> Cosmopolis enshrines the collective virtues which a society may need to recover from the moral remnants of her fallen state. It has to do with enlightening citizens to have a change of mindset and apply all their material and spiritual energies in rebuilding their mentality, personality and spirituality in a way that their humanity comes first before their ego. If people have converted minds, they will

<sup>48</sup> Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 242.

<sup>49</sup> Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 242.

<sup>50</sup> Whelan, *Redeeming History*, 34.

<sup>51</sup> Cf. Shute, *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History*, 57.

<sup>52</sup> Robert Doran, *Subject and Psyche: Ricoeur, Jung, and the Search for Foundations* (Milwaukee: Marquette University Press, 1994), 224.

<sup>53</sup> Ani, *Critical History*, 330.

<sup>54</sup> Cf. Ani, *Critical History*, 330.

adopt cosmopolitan mindset as human citizens, whose humanity obliges to think well and live well. When this is mediated by informed faith and hope, where one sees his or her actions in consequences that lie beyond his present performances, then the potential for recovery is made. This means inspiring and mediating our day by day actions with a deeper sense of history and mystery. In this frame of mind, one would understand that one's actions have historical implications for his present situation, and for the future generation; and that one's actions have eschatological focus in a mysterious finality that lies beyond the earthly one. Engagement in the sublation of meaning, conversion of mind and heart, enlightened morality and spirituality, mediated by insight and cosmopolitan virtues, should form the fundamental fibers as we build the practical, the intellectual, the rational, the moral and the spiritual essentials in the national crusade to restore ourselves as individuals and as a country, Nigeria.

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